

able to compete by lowering prices, Safeway, A&P, and seven other chains and gasoline dealers formed the Blue Stamp Company, once again drawing the ire of the Justice Department. In 1963, they were charged with an antitrust suit for attempting to establish a trading stamp monopoly.

Trading stamp usage started to decline in the early 1970s and worsened when service stations dropped out of the programs during the gas shortage of the mid-1970s. Sperry & Hutchinson alone lost a quarter of its entire stamp business overnight. The last supermarket to give out the paper stamps was a Piggly Wiggly store in Columbia, Tennessee. That store finally gave them up in February 2003, leaving trading stamp books mostly a fond memory in the minds of the housewives who'd saved them. Surprisingly, Sperry & Hutchinson is still in business, with a modernized version of stamps, "greenpoints." No more licking and sticking, greenpoints are earned by shopping with the Sperry & Hutchinson card at participating grocery partners or online through their website. The points are accumulated and can be exchanged for gift cards to stores like Gap and Borders.

Grocery stores and gas stations weren't the only ones offering great deals. Naturally, cereal manufacturers that had been at the forefront in offering coupons on their products had to get in on the premium action too. Cereal makers began giving items such as spoons, cups, and even rag dolls either inside the boxes or through the mail with proofs of purchase. Kellogg's offered one of the first copyrighted novelty items in 1910, a Jungleland moving picture book. Children could interchange the cut-out sections of animal heads, bodies and legs in a six-page folder in the initial offer.